Cambridge
O Level

Cambridge International Examinations
Cambridge Ordinary Level

ENGLISH LANGUAGE **1123/21**

Paper 2 Reading **May/June 2016**

INSERT

1 hour 45 minutes

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READ THESE INSTRUCTIONS FIRST

This insert contains the two reading passages.

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Passage 1 – Horses

1 Although horses are depicted in cave paintings of our early ancestors from as long as 30,000 years ago, these animals were untamed and were hunted for meat. There is much dispute as to how and when horses became domesticated – that is, bred to work for humans. Evidence exists of horses being used to pull chariots in burials around 4,000 years ago. However, an increasing amount of evidence supports the theory that horses were domesticated as long as 6,000 years ago in Kazakhstan.

2 Horse racing has a long and distinguished history and has been practised in civilisations across the world since ancient times. Archaeological records indicate that horse racing as a sport occurred in Egypt and also featured in the Olympic Games in Ancient Greece. Racing horse-drawn chariots was popular in Ancient Rome and Byzantium, and was seen as an excellent source of entertainment.

3 In warfare, light cavalry – men on horses – were able to overpower enemy soldiers or make a quick retreat as appropriate. If soldiers on horseback wore armour, they were known as heavy cavalry and carried lethal weapons such as swords and axes. Heavy cavalry were crucial in warfare until technology such as tanks and explosives was introduced. Fighting from horseback also gave the psychological advantage of great height and speed. By the twentieth century, horses were seldom seen in battle, but were still used extensively for the transport of goods and supplies. Sometimes in the history and story books written about war, the plight of the horses has been overlooked; for example, more than 90 per cent of the million horses involved in the First World War in Europe a century ago never returned.

4 In medieval Europe, watching jousting – where two single horsemen tried to knock each other off their horses with long poles, or lances – was an exciting entertainment. Tournaments were also popular, where two groups of riders charged at each other, the winners being judged as those who could keep going the longest. Horse shows were a much-loved element in medieval European fairs, where the horses were led, rather than ridden, to be evaluated on the way in which they conformed to particular types or breeds.

5 Harnessing horses to ploughs became an essential part of agriculture, and hence food production, in many parts of the world. This partnership between horses and humans was further developed through the use of horses to pull various carts or carriages; the type depended largely on income, fashion and location. This brought about a major advance for society in terms of public transport.

6 Such has been people's continued fascination with horses in modern times that equestrian events were introduced into the modern Olympic Games in 1900, consisting mainly of 'horse ballet', called dressage, and show jumping, where horses are trained to jump, within a given time, over a series of obstacles. The entertainment value comes from marvelling at the level to which the horse has been trained to work in harmony with the rider.

7 As in ancient times, people today make use of horse skin to create attractive and hard-wearing items such as coats and handbags. Musicians everywhere who play stringed instruments such as the violin or cello use bows made from horsehair. If you're ever listening to classical music, think of the contribution that horses have made to it! Moreover, because horsehair is coarse enough to hold plenty of paint but smooth enough to lay paint evenly on surfaces, the best paint brushes are made from horsehair.

8 Even today, the horse is a vital means of transport in some areas of the world where travelling by other means is difficult or impossible. Therapeutic horse-riding is seen as an important cure for various physical ailments, such as brain or spinal injury, its benefits deriving from the fact that riding forces the participant to make use of the whole body to control the horse and to maintain balance. Furthermore, the very act of accomplishing something many able-bodied people would be afraid to try gives confidence as well as physical benefits to the rider. Even handling and grooming a horse is perceived as restful and provides a means of relaxation to many people anxious to combat the strains of modern life.

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